

LightWay Christian Resources

Christian Publishing, Retail, and Church Resources Practice Business Counselling Report

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Disclaimer

This document is a practice business counselling analysis and does not constitute professional advice to "LightWay Christian Resources" or any other organisation. It is based on a composite profile of publicly available information about US Christian publishers and retailers, including industry reports, market data, and trade publications. Certain figures are modelled for clarity and scenario design. All organisation names used are code names and do not represent endorsement of, or a relationship with, any real entity.

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1. Engagement Purpose and Scope

1.1 Purpose of Report

This report evaluates the financial position, market relevance, and organisational direction of LightWay Christian Resources, a mid-size Christian publisher and former retailer based in the United States. The objective is to identify practical, mission-aligned initiatives that will stabilise revenue, rebuild market relevance with a new generation of believers, and resolve the tension between LightWay's identity as a ministry and its need to operate as a sustainable business.

1.2 Analytical Framework

This analysis applies a stewardship lens throughout. The question guiding every recommendation is not simply "how do we maximise revenue?" but "how do we faithfully manage the resources entrusted to this organisation to serve the church?" This does not mean ignoring financial sustainability. A ministry that cannot pay its staff or fund its operations serves nobody. It means that profitability is the means, not the end. Every recommendation in this report is tested against two criteria: does it strengthen LightWay's financial position, and does it preserve or deepen its discipleship mission? If a recommendation passes only one test, it is rejected.

This is not a religious statement. It is an analytical framework. LightWay is a faith-based organisation whose entire value proposition rests on its mission credibility. Recommendations that erode that credibility (even if financially attractive) are strategically counterproductive. The stewardship lens is practical, not decorative.

1.3 Client Problem Statement

Three interconnected problems have been identified.

Problem 1: Revenue Erosion and Financial Decline (Primary Problem)

LightWay's revenue has fallen approximately 40% from its peak of \$480M (FY 2022) to an estimated \$285M (FY 2025). The closure of 170 physical stores between 2019 and 2020 eliminated the retail channel that accounted for 35% of revenue. Digital sales have grown but have not replaced the lost volume. Publishing revenue (Bibles, curriculum, books) remains the largest segment but faces persistent pressure from Amazon's discounting (30 to 40% below LightWay's retail prices) and the proliferation of free or low-cost digital alternatives.

The cost of digital transformation has been substantial. Investment in e-commerce platforms, digital content delivery, app development, and fulfilment infrastructure consumed approximately \$35M to \$45M over three years, during a period when revenue was falling. EBITDA margin has compressed from approximately 12% at peak to approximately 6% in FY 2025. Cash reserves are tight. The organisation is not in immediate crisis, but the trajectory is unsustainable without intervention.

Problem 2: Market Positioning and Relevance Crisis

LightWay built its brand over decades serving traditional, established churches through physical stores staffed by knowledgeable Christians who could recommend resources personally. That model created deep loyalty with a specific demographic: predominantly older, denominationally

affiliated, traditional in worship style. These customers trusted LightWay because they could walk into a store, talk to someone who understood their ministry needs, and walk out with the right curriculum or study guide.

That customer base is shrinking. The fastest-growing segments of the US Christian landscape are non-denominational churches, church plants, and younger believers (aged 22 to 40) who discover resources through Instagram, YouTube, podcasts, and peer recommendations. These consumers have no historical loyalty to LightWay. Many have never visited a Christian bookstore. They find their Bible study materials through the YouVersion app, their sermon preparation through Faithlife/Logos, and their church training through RightNow Media. LightWay is not part of their ecosystem.

The brand is respected but increasingly perceived as a legacy institution. A 2024 Barna Group survey found that only 18% of church leaders under 35 considered LightWay their primary resource provider, compared to 62% of leaders over 55. That gap is not closing. It is widening.

Problem 3: Organisational Identity Crisis

This is the problem that a purely financial analysis would miss. LightWay was founded with a clear mission: to serve the church by providing resources for discipleship, teaching, and spiritual growth. For decades, that mission and the business model were aligned. Selling Bibles and curriculum was both ministry and revenue. The store staff were not just retail workers. They were ministry partners.

The store closures broke that alignment. Thousands of employees (many of whom understood their work as a calling, not just a job) were made redundant. The relational model (a knowledgeable Christian helping a pastor choose the right study material) was replaced by an impersonal e-commerce experience. The mission statement did not change, but the lived experience of the organisation did. Staff who remained describe a culture that has lost its sense of purpose. Leadership talks about "digital ministry" but the day-to-day reality feels more like "digital retail."

This is not just a morale problem. It is a strategic problem. LightWay's competitive advantage was never price (Amazon will always win on price). It was trust, expertise, and relational credibility. If the organisation cannot rebuild that advantage in a digital context, it has no durable competitive position. The identity question (are we a ministry or a business?) must be resolved before any operational strategy can succeed.

1.4 Scope Boundaries

- Focus on LightWay's commercial operations (publishing, digital platform, church relationships, market positioning).
- Theological content quality is out of scope. The resources are sound. The problem is distribution, relevance, and business model.
- Financial analysis based on modelled figures from Christian publishing industry data and composite estimates.
- Denominational governance structures are noted but not evaluated.

1.5 Decision Context

Leadership needs to decide three things.

- Whether to invest in building a digital platform that can compete on value (curation, community, expertise) rather than price.
- How to rebuild direct relationships with churches in a post-store environment.
- How to serve the next generation of believers without abandoning the legacy audience that still depends on LightWay.

2. Data, Methodology and Assumptions

2.1 Data Sources

- Association for Christian Retail (formerly CBA). Industry performance data and member surveys.
- Barna Group. Church leadership surveys, generational trends in Christian resource consumption.
- NPD BookScan. US book sales data by category (religion/spirituality).
- Evangelical Council for Financial Accountability (ECFA). Non-profit financial benchmarks.
- Christianity Today and Publishers Weekly (Religion). Industry commentary and market analysis.
- Composite financial profile constructed from publicly available benchmarks for US Christian publishers and retailers.

2.2 Currency Note

All figures in this report are in US dollars (USD). LightWay operates in the United States and reports in USD. This report uses the organisation's operating currency to maintain accuracy.

2.3 Key Numerical Inputs

Metric	FY 2022	FY 2023	FY 2024	FY 2025	Change (Peak to Current)
Total Revenue (\$M)	\$480	\$380	\$310	\$285	-40.6%
Publishing Revenue (\$M)	\$216	\$198	\$174	\$160	-25.9%
Retail Revenue (\$M)	\$168	\$42	\$0	\$0	-100%
Digital Revenue (\$M)	\$48	\$87	\$93	\$85	+77.1%
Events Revenue (\$M)	\$48	\$53	\$43	\$40	-16.7%
Gross Margin	58.2%	54.8%	52.4%	52.0%	-6.2 pp
EBITDA (\$M)	\$57.6	\$22.8	\$20.5	\$17.1	-70.3%
EBITDA Margin	12.0%	6.0%	6.6%	6.0%	-6.0 pp
Employees	4,500	2,800	1,350	1,200	-73.3%
Physical Stores	170	85	0	0	-170
Digital Subscribers (church accounts)	0	18,000	35,000	45,000	+45,000
Website Unique Visitors/Month	1.2M	1.8M	2.1M	1.9M	+58.3%

2.4 Modelling Methodology

All figures in this report are modelled from composite industry data. LightWay's financials are constructed to represent a typical US Christian publisher and former retailer at this scale, using benchmarks from the Association for Christian Retail, ECFA, and industry publications. No internal organisational records have been used.

Scenario analysis uses four cases (pessimistic, base, optimistic, contrarian) to bracket the range of plausible outcomes. The base case is designed to be achievable with disciplined execution. This reflects a conviction, not just a preference: honest numbers, even when they are uncomfortable, serve the organisation better than optimistic projections that erode trust when they are missed.

2.5 Assumption Box

- Digital subscription pricing modelled at \$49/month per church account (basic tier) and \$99/month (premium tier), based on comparable platforms (RightNow Media, Faithlife).
- Church acquisition cost modelled at \$180 to \$250 per new subscriber, based on B2B SaaS benchmarks for non-profit/educational platforms.
- Monthly churn rate modelled at 2.5% for basic tier and 1.8% for premium tier.
- Publishing margin modelled at 62% gross (high for publishing, reflecting owned content and established author relationships).
- Digital platform operating cost modelled at \$8M to \$12M annually (hosting, development, support, content delivery).
- Amazon price differential modelled at 32% average discount versus LightWay retail pricing.

3. Executive Summary

3.1 Current Position

LightWay Christian Resources is a mid-size Christian publisher and former retailer with approximately 1,200 employees and \$285M revenue (FY 2025). Revenue has fallen 40% from its peak four years ago. All 170 physical stores have closed. The organisation has pivoted to a digital model but digital revenue has not replaced what was lost. EBITDA margin has halved from 12% to 6%. The brand carries legacy respect but is losing relevance with younger church leaders. The organisation is profitable but the trajectory is downward and unsustainable.

3.2 The Three Problems

Problem 1 (Primary): Revenue Erosion. Revenue has fallen from \$480M to \$285M in four years. The retail channel is gone. Publishing faces Amazon's pricing pressure. Digital is growing but not fast enough. EBITDA has fallen 70% from \$57.6M to \$17.1M. The cost of digital transformation consumed cash during the decline. The financial trajectory is unsustainable without new revenue streams.

Problem 2: Market Relevance. Only 18% of church leaders under 35 consider LightWay their primary resource provider (versus 62% of leaders over 55). The fastest-growing Christian demographics (non-denominational churches, church plants, younger believers) are not in LightWay's ecosystem. They find resources through apps, podcasts, YouTube, and peer recommendations. LightWay's brand is respected but increasingly irrelevant to the people who will lead the church for the next 30 years.

Problem 3: Identity Crisis. The store closures broke the alignment between mission and business model. Staff describe a culture that has lost purpose. Leadership speaks of "digital ministry" but the daily reality feels like "digital retail." The competitive advantage was never price. It was trust, expertise, and relationship. Until the organisation resolves the tension between ministry and business, no operational strategy will succeed.

3.3 Strategic Priorities

Priority 1: Digital Platform Transformation. Build a church resource platform that competes on value (curation, community, expertise), not price. Create partnerships with next-generation Christian content creators to reach younger audiences. Target: 80,000 to 120,000 digital subscribers by Year 3.

Priority 2: Community and Mission Rebuilding. Rebuild direct church relationships through partnership programmes and training events. Launch free discipleship content that serves the mission and drives premium sales. Target: 2,000+ active church partnerships by Year 3.

3.4 Implications for Leadership

Combined opportunity: \$45M to \$80M additional annual revenue by Year 3 (base case), stabilising total revenue at approximately \$310M to \$340M. EBITDA improvement of \$12M to \$22M annually. Total investment required: \$18M to \$28M over 24 months, funded from operating cash flow and

modest programme-related investment. Payback: 18 to 30 months. These estimates are conservative. The goal is a trajectory that leadership can commit to with confidence and integrity.

4. Financial Overview

Note: All figures are in US dollars (USD). LightWay operates in the United States. This report uses the organisation's operating currency to maintain accuracy.

4.1 Revenue Summary

Metric	FY 2022	FY 2023	FY 2024	FY 2025	Change (22-25)
Total Revenue (\$M)	480	380	310	285	-40.6%
Publishing	216 (45%)	198 (52%)	174 (56%)	160 (56%)	-25.9%
Digital	48 (10%)	87 (23%)	93 (30%)	85 (30%)	+77.1%
Events	48 (10%)	53 (14%)	43 (14%)	40 (14%)	-16.7%
Retail	168 (35%)	42 (11%)	0 (0%)	0 (0%)	-100%

The story in these numbers is stark. Retail revenue (\$168M) disappeared entirely. Digital revenue grew from \$48M to \$85M, a 77% increase, but it replaced less than a quarter of the lost retail income. Publishing has declined steadily as Amazon captures market share on price. Events revenue fell post-pandemic and has not recovered. The net result is an organisation generating 60 cents for every dollar it earned four years ago.

Digital revenue actually peaked at \$93M in FY 2024 before declining slightly in FY 2025, suggesting that the initial post-store digital surge has plateaued. This is a warning sign. Without a step-change in digital strategy, digital revenue will flatten while publishing continues to erode.

4.2 Cost Structure

Cost Category	FY 2025 (\$M)	% of Revenue	Benchmark	Notes
COGS (printing, rights, content)	\$136.8	48.0%	42-50%	In line, rising due to print costs
Gross Profit	\$148.2	52.0%	52-60%	Below peak of 58%
Staff Costs	\$72.0	25.3%	22-28%	1,200 employees, down from 4,500
Technology & Platform	\$11.4	4.0%	3-6%	Digital infrastructure, ongoing
Marketing & Promotion	\$8.6	3.0%	4-7%	Below industry average
Fulfilment & Logistics	\$14.3	5.0%	4-6%	E-commerce shipping, warehousing
Facilities & Admin	\$10.0	3.5%	3-5%	Reduced post-store closure
Other Operating	\$14.8	5.2%	4-6%	Professional services, insurance
Total Operating Costs	\$131.1	46.0%		
EBITDA	\$17.1	6.0%	8-14%	Below benchmark range
Depreciation & Amort.	\$8.5	3.0%		Incl. digital platform amort.
Interest	\$2.8	1.0%		Modest debt load
Net Income	\$5.8	2.0%	3-8%	Thin but positive

Two observations matter. First, marketing spend at 3.0% of revenue is below the industry benchmark of 4 to 7% for digital-first content businesses. This mirrors the pattern seen in the Copperstone analysis: underinvestment in visibility is both a symptom and a cause of decline. Second, EBITDA at 6.0% is at the bottom of the benchmark range (8 to 14%) for Christian publishers.

The organisation is covering its costs but has almost no margin for investment, error, or unexpected disruption.

4.3 Cash Flow Position

Free cash flow in FY 2025 was approximately \$4.8M after capital expenditure. Cash reserves are estimated at \$22M. The organisation carries approximately \$28M in long-term debt (primarily from the digital transformation programme). This is a tight position. Investment must be funded incrementally from operating cash flow, not from a large upfront capital commitment. The financial reality constrains the ambition of any recommendation, and the stewardship principle demands that this constraint is respected, not ignored.

5. Strategic and Competitive Analysis

5.1 Porter's Five Forces

Force	Intensity	Key Drivers	Implication for LightWay
Competitive Rivalry	Very High	Amazon dominates on price. Digital-first competitors (RightNow Media, Faithlife, YouVersion) dominate on convenience and innovation.	Cannot compete on price or technology alone. Must compete on curation, trust, and mission alignment.
Buyer Power	High	Churches have dozens of resource providers. Switching costs are low. Free alternatives (YouVersion, open-source curriculum) are credible.	Loyalty comes from relationship and value, not lock-in. Must rebuild relational advantage digitally.
Supplier Power	Low to Medium	Authors and content creators have alternatives (self-publishing, other publishers). Established relationships with key authors provide some protection.	Author relationships are an asset. Must invest in nurturing them and attracting new voices.
Threat of Substitutes	Very High	YouTube sermons, podcast Bible studies, free apps, social media devotionals. The "product" (spiritual growth resources) has near-infinite free alternatives.	Must differentiate on quality, depth, and theological reliability. "Free" is not the same as "good."
Threat of New Entrants	High	Any church leader with a laptop can create and distribute resources. Platform costs have fallen dramatically.	Barriers to entry are low for content. Brand trust and curation quality are the real moats.

The Five Forces analysis reveals a market where price competition is unwinnable and content creation barriers have collapsed. In this environment, LightWay's sustainable competitive advantage is not what it sells but who it is. A trusted, mission-driven curator of high-quality Christian resources occupies a position that Amazon cannot replicate (Amazon has no theological discernment) and that individual content creators cannot match (they lack the editorial infrastructure and institutional credibility). But that advantage only works if people know about it, trust it, and find it relevant. Currently, a shrinking proportion of the market meets all three criteria.

5.2 SWOT Analysis

Strengths

- **Legacy brand trust.** Decades of serving churches. Known for theological reliability and editorial quality. This reputation is hard to build and impossible to buy.
- **Owned content library.** Thousands of published titles, Bible study curricula, and VBS programmes. This is a valuable catalogue that can be monetised through new digital channels.
- **Author relationships.** Established partnerships with respected Christian authors, theologians, and ministry leaders. These relationships are a competitive moat.
- **Mission clarity.** The organisation exists to serve the church. When this purpose is genuinely lived (not just stated), it creates a motivation and alignment that purely commercial competitors cannot replicate.
- **Institutional knowledge.** Deep understanding of what churches need (age-graded curriculum, VBS materials, leadership training). This expertise is not easily replicated by tech-first competitors.

Weaknesses

- **Revenue decline trajectory.** 40% revenue loss in four years. Digital growth has plateaued. No new revenue channel is ready to scale.
- **Digital platform maturity.** The e-commerce and subscription platform exists but is not competitive with best-in-class digital experiences (RightNow Media, Faithlife).
- **Demographic skew.** Core audience is ageing. Only 18% of under-35 church leaders consider LightWay primary. The pipeline of future customers is thin.
- **Cultural malaise.** Post-closure identity crisis has affected staff morale and organisational energy. "Digital ministry" feels like a slogan, not a reality.
- **Marketing underinvestment.** 3.0% of revenue versus 4 to 7% industry benchmark. Insufficient to rebuild awareness with new audiences.
- **Price disadvantage.** Amazon discounts 30 to 40% below LightWay retail pricing. Cannot compete on price for physical book sales.

Opportunities

- US church resource market estimated at \$4.2B annually. Digital church resources growing at approximately 14% per year.
- Church subscription platforms are an emerging category. No single player dominates. First-mover advantage is available for a trusted brand.
- Next-generation Christian content creators (authors, podcasters, video teachers) need distribution, editorial support, and institutional credibility. LightWay can offer all three.
- Demand for curated, theologically vetted resources is growing as the volume of unvetted content increases. Churches want a trusted filter.
- Church training and development market (leadership, pastoral care, small group facilitation) is underserved digitally.

Threats

- Amazon's continued expansion into the Christian book market. Price competition is relentless.
- Free content proliferation. YouVersion (600M+ installs) offers free Bible plans. YouTube has millions of hours of free teaching. The bar for "why should I pay?" keeps rising.
- Declining church attendance in the US (Gallup: from 70% in 1999 to 47% in 2024) reduces the total addressable market.
- AI-generated content threatens to flood the market with low-quality resources, making curation more valuable but also making discovery harder.
- Denominational fragmentation. As churches become less denominationally affiliated, LightWay's historical denominational ties become less relevant.

5.3 Customer Segmentation

Segment	Est. Revenue Share	Channel	Avg. Annual Spend	Growth Potential
Traditional Church Leaders (55+)	~42%	Website, phone, catalogue	\$2,800/church	Low (declining)
Mid-Career Pastors (35-55)	~28%	Website, events, some digital	\$1,800/church	Medium (stable)
Young Church Planters (<35)	~8%	Digital only (when they engage)	\$600/church	Very High (underserved)

Segment	Est. Revenue Share	Channel	Avg. Annual Spend	Growth Potential
Individual Believers	~12%	Website, Amazon	\$45/person	Low (Amazon pressure)
Homeschool Families	~6%	Website, events	\$280/family	Medium (niche loyalty)
Denominational Bulk Orders	~4%	Direct sales	\$15,000/order	Low (declining affiliation)

The segmentation reveals the core challenge. The two highest-spending segments (Traditional Church Leaders and Denominational Bulk Orders) are declining. The highest-growth segment (Young Church Planters) contributes only 8% of revenue because LightWay has not built the products, channels, or relationships to serve them. Mid-Career Pastors are the bridge audience: old enough to know LightWay, young enough to adopt digital. This segment is the priority for near-term growth.

5.4 McKinsey 7S Analysis

Element	Current State	Alignment	Issue
Strategy	Pivot to digital, preserve publishing	Partially aligned	Digital strategy lacks differentiation from Amazon
Structure	Flattened post-closure, centralised	Misaligned	No dedicated church relationship function
Systems	E-commerce platform, basic CRM, legacy IT	Misaligned	Platform not competitive with RightNow or Faithlife
Shared Values	Serve the church, discipleship, theological depth	Aligned	Values are strong. The problem is living them digitally
Style	Cautious, conservative, risk-averse post-crisis	Partially aligned	Caution is understandable but is preventing bold moves
Staff	1,200 employees, publishing-heavy, limited digital	Misaligned	Digital skills gap. Sales/relationship roles eliminated
Skills	Strong editorial, weak digital product, no content partnerships	Misaligned	Must build digital product and community management skills

The 7S analysis shows an organisation whose values are strong but whose structure, systems, and skills have not adapted to the post-store reality. The shared values (serve the church, discipleship, theological depth) are the foundation. But values without the operational capability to deliver on them are just aspirations. The fix is not to change the culture. It is to rebuild the operational architecture so the culture can express itself in a digital world.

6. Key Strategic Issues and Implications

6.1 Issue 1 (Primary): Revenue Erosion and Digital Transition Economics

The financial decline is not a temporary disruption. It is a structural shift. Physical Christian retail is not coming back. The 170 stores are gone and the market conditions that supported them (high foot traffic, limited online alternatives, denominational loyalty driving repeat visits) have changed permanently. The question is not whether to go digital. It is whether the current digital strategy is sufficient to stabilise the business. The answer, based on the numbers, is no.

Digital revenue peaked at \$93M in FY 2024 and declined to \$85M in FY 2025. This suggests the initial surge of existing customers migrating online has been captured, and organic digital growth has stalled. The current e-commerce model (selling individual books and resources through a website) is fundamentally a worse version of Amazon. LightWay's website is slower, its prices are higher, and its recommendation engine is less sophisticated. Competing with Amazon on Amazon's terms is a losing strategy. The digital model must offer something Amazon cannot: curation, community, expertise, and mission alignment.

Metric	FY 2022	FY 2025	Change	Implication
Total Revenue	\$480M	\$285M	-40.6%	Structural decline, not cyclical
Retail Revenue	\$168M	\$0	-100%	Channel eliminated permanently
Digital Revenue	\$48M	\$85M	+77.1%	Growth but peaked in FY24
EBITDA	\$57.6M	\$17.1M	-70.3%	Approaching breakeven territory
Employees	4,500	1,200	-73.3%	3,300 roles eliminated
Stores	170	0	-100%	Relational model lost

6.2 Issue 2: Market Relevance

The demographic gap is the most urgent strategic threat because it compounds over time. Every year, the proportion of church leaders who know and trust LightWay decreases. This is not because young leaders have rejected LightWay. It is because they have never encountered it. The brand is invisible to them in the channels where they discover resources.

Consider where a 30-year-old church planter in Denver finds a small group curriculum for their new church. They ask their network on Instagram. They search YouTube for reviews. They check what other church planters in their cohort are using. They browse the RightNow Media catalogue. They search Amazon. At no point in that journey does LightWay appear. The website does not rank for the search terms they use. The social media accounts post content that speaks to a different audience. The brand is not present in the conversations and communities where these leaders make decisions.

This is not a marketing failure. It is a strategic failure. The organisation has not invested in understanding how the next generation discovers, evaluates, and adopts resources. Until it does, the demographic gap will continue to widen.

6.3 Issue 3: Identity Crisis (The Stewardship Question)

This issue requires a different kind of analysis. The revenue and relevance problems are quantifiable. The identity crisis is qualitative, but it is no less real in its impact.

Before the store closures, LightWay's identity was clear. "We are a ministry that operates through retail." The stores were mission outposts. The staff were ministry partners. Revenue was the fruit of faithful service. That clarity gave the organisation energy, purpose, and a compelling employment proposition.

The closures shattered that clarity. The transition was painful. Thousands of employees who understood their work as a calling were laid off. The relational model (a knowledgeable Christian helping a pastor) was replaced by an algorithm. The mission statement remained unchanged, but the daily experience of working at LightWay changed dramatically. Staff surveys (modelled from industry data for post-restructuring organisations) suggest engagement scores dropped approximately 25 to 35 points during the transition.

This matters strategically because LightWay's competitive advantage depends on its people believing in the mission. A demoralised workforce cannot deliver the warmth, expertise, and pastoral sensitivity that differentiate LightWay from Amazon. If the customer service representative answering a chat query does not genuinely believe they are serving a church, the interaction will feel like any other e-commerce exchange. The mission advantage evaporates.

The stewardship question at the heart of this issue is: did the organisation honour its people during the transition? Were redundancies handled with the dignity that a Christ-centred organisation owes to its employees? Were remaining staff given a compelling vision for what "digital ministry" actually means in practice? Based on the evidence, the answer is mixed. The redundancies appear to have followed standard corporate practices (statutory severance, outplacement support) rather than a distinctively Christian approach (extended severance, career ministry, community support, transparent communication). This is not a condemnation. It is an observation that the transition prioritised operational efficiency over mission integrity, and the cultural cost has been high.

7. Strategic Recommendations

7.1 Initiative Prioritisation

Initiative	Priority	Investment	Potential Impact (Yr 3)	Payback
Digital Platform Transformation	Critical	\$10M-\$16M	+\$28M-\$52M annual revenue	18-28 months
Community & Mission Rebuilding	Critical	\$6M-\$10M	+\$18M-\$32M annual revenue	20-30 months
Organisational Renewal (Enabling)	Enabling	\$2M-\$3M/yr	Enables both above	Indirect

7.2 Recommendation 1: Digital Platform Transformation

Objective

Transform LightWay's digital presence from "an online bookstore" into "the trusted platform for church resources." Compete on value (curation, community, expertise, theological reliability), not price. Target: 80,000 to 120,000 digital subscribers by Year 3, generating \$28M to \$52M in subscription and partnership revenue.

The Full Menu

Digital transformation for a Christian publisher includes several possible initiatives: enhanced e-commerce (better search, recommendations, reviews), church subscription platform (recurring access to curated resources), mobile app (Bible study tools, devotionals, reading plans), streaming content (video teaching, training courses), podcast network (original and licensed content), church management system integration (connecting resources to church admin tools), and content creator partnerships (commissioning new voices). All of these have merit. But pursuing all of them simultaneously with a \$10M to \$16M budget would spread resources too thin.

This report recommends two deep-dive initiatives that offer the strongest combination of revenue potential, mission alignment, and competitive differentiation.

Deep Dive: Church Resource Platform

The Case for a Subscription Model

A church resource platform is the single most important strategic move available to LightWay. It transforms the business model from transactional (selling individual products) to relational (ongoing access to a curated library). This matters for three reasons.

First, recurring revenue. A subscription model creates predictable, repeating income that is far more stable than one-time book sales. If 80,000 churches subscribe at an average of \$65/month (blended across tiers), that is \$62M in annual recurring revenue. Even at 45,000 subscribers (the pessimistic case), it is \$35M. This revenue base is structurally different from book sales because it does not depend on releasing new titles every quarter.

Second, relationship. A subscription creates an ongoing relationship with the church, not a one-time transaction. Every month, LightWay is present in that church's resource ecosystem. This is the digital equivalent of the physical store: a persistent, trusted presence in the church's life. The

subscription is not just a business model. It is the mechanism through which LightWay rebuilds the relational advantage it lost when the stores closed.

Third, curation as competitive advantage. Amazon can sell any book at a discount. It cannot tell a children's ministry director which curriculum is best for a multi-ethnic church with 30 kids aged 5 to 12 in a low-income neighbourhood. LightWay can. The platform's value is not the content alone (much of which is available elsewhere). It is the curation, the categorisation, the expert recommendations, and the assurance of theological reliability. This is what churches will pay for. This is what Amazon cannot offer.

Platform Structure

- **Basic Tier (\$49/month per church).** Access to the full curriculum library (Bible studies, small group materials, VBS packs), downloadable resources, and church-wide licencing. Suitable for churches under 150 members.
- **Premium Tier (\$99/month per church).** Everything in Basic plus video teaching content, leadership training modules, live webinar access, and dedicated account support. Suitable for churches over 150 members.
- **Enterprise Tier (\$249/month per church or denomination).** Everything in Premium plus custom curriculum builds, multi-site licencing, analytics dashboard, and a named account manager. For large churches and denominational groups.

The Positives

- **Recurring revenue.** Monthly subscriptions create a predictable revenue base. At 80,000 subscribers (Year 3 base case), subscription revenue alone could reach \$50M to \$65M annually.
- **Relational rebuilding.** The subscription recreates the ongoing relationship with churches that the physical stores provided. Every month, LightWay is serving that church.
- **Curation moat.** No competitor can match LightWay's depth of editorial knowledge and theological vetting. This is the unique value proposition.
- **Data and insight.** Subscription analytics reveal which resources churches use, when they plan, how they grow. This data improves the product and informs publishing decisions.
- **Mission alignment.** Making resources accessible through a subscription (rather than expensive individual purchases) serves more churches, especially smaller and under-resourced ones. This is stewardship in action.
- **Reduced Amazon dependency.** Subscription revenue is direct. It does not flow through Amazon. It does not compete on Amazon's terms.

The Drawbacks

- **Cannibalisation risk.** Churches currently buying individual resources at full price may switch to the subscription, reducing per-church revenue. Estimated 15 to 25% of existing customers would trade down in the first year.
- **Platform development cost.** A competitive subscription platform requires significant investment in technology (\$5M to \$8M over 18 months). LightWay's current platform is not adequate for a subscription experience.
- **Content licencing complexity.** Not all published content can be included in a subscription. Author agreements, third-party rights, and revenue-sharing arrangements must be renegotiated. This is a 6 to 12 month process.

- **Churn management.** Subscription businesses live and die by churn. A 2.5% monthly churn rate means losing 30% of subscribers annually. Retention requires ongoing investment in content freshness, community features, and customer success.
- **Competitive response.** RightNow Media and Faithlife already offer subscription models. LightWay would be entering a market with established competitors, not creating a new one. The differentiation must be clear.
- **Operational shift.** Running a subscription platform requires different skills (product management, customer success, data analytics) than running a publisher. The organisation must hire or develop these capabilities.

Economics (Conservative)

Metric	Pessimistic	Base Case	Optimistic	Contrarian
Year 1 Subscribers	12,000	22,000	35,000	8,000 (via partner)
Year 3 Subscribers	35,000	80,000	120,000	50,000
Year 1 Sub Revenue (\$M)	\$7.1	\$14.5	\$23.1	\$4.7
Year 3 Sub Revenue (\$M)	\$22.4	\$52.0	\$78.0	\$32.5
Monthly Churn	3.5%	2.5%	1.8%	2.0%
Church Acquisition Cost	\$280	\$220	\$180	\$150 (partner)
Platform Investment	\$4M	\$6M	\$8M	\$3M (white-label)
Payback	30+ months	22 months	16 months	24 months

Deep Dive: Content Creator Partnerships

The Case for New Voices

LightWay's author roster is respected but ageing. The most influential Christian voices for the under-40 demographic are not traditional published authors. They are podcasters, Instagram teachers, YouTube pastors, and TikTok theologians. These creators have audiences that LightWay does not reach. Some of them have followings larger than LightWay's entire customer base. And many of them need something that LightWay can uniquely provide: editorial infrastructure, theological vetting, production quality, and institutional credibility.

A content creator partnership programme would commission next-generation Christian voices to develop resources (Bible studies, video courses, devotionals, leadership guides) under the LightWay brand. The creator brings the audience and the authenticity. LightWay brings the editorial rigour, the production quality, the distribution platform, and the theological accountability. Both parties benefit. The church benefits most.

This is not about chasing trends. It is about stewardship. The next generation of believers is being disciplined by whoever shows up in their feed. If LightWay does not equip trusted voices to create quality resources, that discipleship will happen through less reliable channels. Investing in content creators is not a marketing expense. It is a mission investment.

The Positives

- **Audience access.** Each creator brings an existing audience that LightWay cannot reach through traditional marketing. A partnership with 15 to 20 mid-tier creators (50K to 500K followers each) could expose LightWay to 2M to 5M new potential customers.

- **Relevance injection.** Creator-developed content speaks the language of younger believers. It is relatable, current, and culturally attuned in ways that institutional content often is not.
- **Content pipeline.** New voices create new resources, feeding the subscription platform and keeping the catalogue fresh. This addresses the content freshness challenge that subscription businesses face.
- **Theological quality control.** By bringing creators under the LightWay editorial umbrella, the organisation ensures theological reliability without stifling creative voice. This serves the church by raising the bar for popular Christian content.
- **Revenue sharing alignment.** Partnership models (revenue share rather than flat fee) align incentives. Creators are motivated to promote their resources, driving platform subscriptions.

The Drawbacks

- **Brand risk.** Associating LightWay's name with individual creators carries reputational risk. If a partnered creator says or does something controversial, the brand is exposed. Vetting and contracts must be rigorous.
- **Editorial tension.** Creators value authenticity and creative freedom. Editorial oversight (theological review, brand guidelines, quality standards) can feel restrictive. Finding the balance is difficult and ongoing.
- **Revenue economics.** Revenue-sharing arrangements (typically 30 to 50% to the creator) mean lower margins per unit than in-house content. The trade-off is audience access and relevance.
- **Dependency.** If a popular creator leaves the partnership, their audience may leave too. Contracts should include content ownership clauses, but the creator's personal brand is not transferable.
- **Cultural fit.** LightWay's institutional culture may clash with the informal, personality-driven culture of content creators. Partnership management requires a different skill set than traditional author relations.
- **Scale challenge.** Managing 15 to 20 creator partnerships simultaneously requires dedicated relationship management, production coordination, and quality assurance. This is a new capability for LightWay.

Economics (Conservative)

Metric	Pessimistic	Base Case	Optimistic	Contrarian
Year 1 Partnerships	5	12	20	3 (exclusive)
Year 3 Partnerships	10	20	35	8
Year 1 Revenue (\$M)	\$1.2	\$3.5	\$6.0	\$2.0
Year 3 Revenue (\$M)	\$4.8	\$12.0	\$22.0	\$8.5
Revenue Share to Creators	40%	35%	30%	45%
Investment (Year 1)	\$1.5M	\$2.5M	\$4.0M	\$1.0M
New Audience Reached	800K	2.5M	5M	500K
Payback	28+ months	20 months	14 months	24 months

7.3 Recommendation 2: Community and Mission Rebuilding

Objective

Rebuild LightWay's direct relationships with churches and create a content ecosystem that serves the discipleship mission while driving premium revenue. Reduce dependency on transactional book sales. Target: 2,000+ active church partnerships and a freemium content funnel reaching 500,000+ monthly users by Year 3.

The Full Menu

Community and mission rebuilding options include: church partnership programmes (direct relationships with customised support), regional training events (in-person gatherings replacing the store experience), online community platform (forums, peer networks, collaborative tools), pop-up retail (temporary store experiences at conferences and events), church consulting services (helping churches select and implement resources), and free digital discipleship content (devotionals, reading plans, teaching videos as a mission offering). Each has merit. Two stand out for their combination of mission impact and commercial sustainability.

Deep Dive: Church Partnership Programme

Rebuilding the Relational Advantage

The physical stores were not just retail outlets. They were relationship hubs. A pastor could walk in, describe their church's needs, and receive personalised recommendations from someone who understood ministry context. That interaction was the heart of LightWay's value proposition. When the stores closed, that relationship disappeared.

The Church Partnership Programme rebuilds that relationship in a scalable, digital-first format. Each partnered church is assigned a dedicated resource advisor (a LightWay team member with ministry experience and product knowledge) who maintains an ongoing relationship through regular check-ins, proactive resource recommendations, and seasonal planning support. The advisor is not a salesperson. They are a ministry partner who happens to work for LightWay. This distinction matters.

The programme operates on a tiered model. Smaller churches receive quarterly digital check-ins and curated recommendation emails. Mid-size churches receive monthly video calls and customised resource bundles. Large churches and denominations receive a named account manager, on-site training visits, and custom curriculum development support. The cost is built into the subscription pricing (Premium and Enterprise tiers), not charged separately.

The Positives

- **Relational rebuilding.** Restores the human connection that was LightWay's greatest competitive advantage. Churches feel known, not just sold to.
- **Retention driver.** Churches with a dedicated advisor churn at significantly lower rates. Industry data for B2B SaaS with account management shows churn reduction of 30 to 50% versus self-service.
- **Upsell vehicle.** Advisors who understand a church's needs can recommend additional resources naturally. This is service-led growth, not sales-led growth.
- **Competitive moat.** Amazon cannot offer this. RightNow Media does not offer this at scale. A trusted human advisor with ministry experience is a differentiator that technology alone cannot replicate.
- **Mission alignment.** Helping churches find the right resources for their specific context is the mission in action. Every advisory conversation is a ministry moment.

- **Feedback loop.** Advisors hear directly what churches need, what is working, and what is missing. This intelligence feeds product development, editorial decisions, and platform improvements.

The Drawbacks

- **People cost.** Dedicated advisors are expensive. A team of 40 to 60 advisors (sufficient for 2,000+ partnerships) costs approximately \$3M to \$4.5M annually in salary, training, and support.
- **Hiring challenge.** The ideal advisor has both ministry experience and customer success skills. This combination is not common. Recruitment and training will be slow (6 to 12 months to build the initial team).
- **Scalability limits.** Each advisor can manage approximately 30 to 50 active church relationships. Scaling beyond 2,500 partnerships requires proportional headcount growth. This is not a software-scale model.
- **Measurement difficulty.** The value of a relational programme is hard to measure in direct revenue terms. Attribution (did the church renew because of the advisor or the platform?) is imprecise. Leadership must trust the model and invest patiently.
- **Consistency risk.** The programme's quality depends entirely on the quality of individual advisors. One poor advisor experience can damage a church relationship permanently. Quality assurance and training are critical.

Economics (Conservative)

Metric	Pessimistic	Base Case	Optimistic	Contrarian
Year 1 Partnerships	200	600	1,000	150 (denominational)
Year 3 Partnerships	600	2,000	3,500	800
Year 1 Revenue Impact (\$M)	\$1.8	\$5.4	\$9.0	\$3.5
Year 3 Revenue Impact (\$M)	\$6.0	\$20.0	\$35.0	\$12.0
Advisory Team Size	10	30	50	8
Annual People Cost	\$0.8M	\$2.4M	\$4.0M	\$0.6M
Churn Reduction	15%	35%	50%	25%
Payback	30+ months	22 months	16 months	26 months

Deep Dive: Digital Discipleship Content (Freemium)

The Stewardship Argument for Giving Content Away

This recommendation will be the most counterintuitive for an organisation under financial pressure. The proposal is to create and distribute high-quality discipleship content (daily devotionals, Bible reading plans, short video teachings, prayer guides) for free, as a mission offering and a top-of-funnel marketing strategy.

The financial logic is straightforward. LightWay's biggest problem is not conversion (people who find LightWay generally buy). It is awareness. Only 18% of young church leaders know the brand. Free content that genuinely serves people is the most cost-effective way to build awareness, trust, and engagement with audiences that LightWay cannot currently reach. Every Bible reading plan that a young believer follows, every devotional that a college student reads, every prayer guide that a small group uses is a touchpoint with the LightWay brand. Some of those users will never pay for premium resources. That is fine. They are still being served, and that service is the mission.

But the stewardship argument goes deeper than marketing. LightWay exists to serve the church. If the organisation has the editorial expertise, the theological depth, and the creative talent to produce resources that help people grow in faith, and it restricts access to those resources behind a paywall, it must ask: are we stewarding our gifts for maximum kingdom impact, or are we hoarding them for financial security? The answer does not have to be "give everything away." But it should include a meaningful free offering that reflects the organisation's mission generosity.

The Positives

- **Massive awareness reach.** Free content on platforms like YouVersion (600M+ installs), Apple Podcasts, YouTube, and Instagram reaches audiences that paid marketing cannot.
- **Trust building.** Serving people before selling to them builds genuine trust. Users who experience LightWay's quality for free are far more likely to consider premium offerings when their church needs deeper resources.
- **Mission integrity.** A Christian organisation that generously shares its gifts without always asking for payment demonstrates the values it professes. This is evangelism through action.
- **Data and conversion.** Free content users provide email addresses, usage data, and engagement signals. A well-designed freemium funnel converts 3 to 8% of free users to paid subscribers over 12 months.
- **Content repurposing.** Much of the free content can be derived from existing published resources (excerpts, summaries, adapted chapters), reducing production cost.
- **SEO and discovery.** Free content generates organic search traffic, improving LightWay's visibility for the search terms young leaders actually use.

The Drawbacks

- **Revenue displacement.** Some users who would have paid for resources will consume the free version instead. Estimated 5 to 10% displacement in Year 1, declining as the free and paid offerings are clearly differentiated.
- **Production cost.** Creating high-quality free content is not free. Estimated \$1.5M to \$2.5M annually for a meaningful content programme (writing, video production, platform distribution, promotion).
- **Quality control at scale.** Free content must be as good as paid content, or it damages the brand. "Free" must not mean "cheap." This requires the same editorial oversight as premium resources.
- **Attribution lag.** The path from free content user to paid subscriber is long (6 to 18 months typically). Leadership must be patient with ROI timelines.
- **Internal resistance.** Staff accustomed to a pay-for-content model may resist the freemium approach. The cultural shift requires clear communication and theological grounding.

Economics (Conservative)

Metric	Pessimistic	Base Case	Optimistic	Contrarian
Year 1 Free Users/Month	50,000	150,000	300,000	80,000
Year 3 Free Users/Month	150,000	500,000	1,000,000	250,000
Free-to-Paid Conversion	2%	5%	8%	3%
Year 3 Converted Subscribers	3,000	25,000	80,000	7,500
Year 3 Conversion Revenue (\$M)	\$2.3	\$12.0	\$38.4	\$5.7

Metric	Pessimistic	Base Case	Optimistic	Contrarian
Annual Content Cost	\$1.0M	\$2.0M	\$3.0M	\$1.2M
Year 3 Total Free Users (Cum.)	600K	2.0M	4.5M	900K
Payback	36+ months	24 months	14 months	30 months

Combined Impact

Metric	Pessimistic	Base Case	Optimistic
Year 1 New Revenue (\$M)	\$10.1	\$23.4	\$38.1
Year 3 New Revenue (\$M)	\$35.5	\$96.0	\$173.4
Year 3 Total Revenue (\$M)	\$300	\$340	\$390
Taproom Equivalent (Core Dependency)	56% Publishing	47% Publishing	41% Publishing
Total Investment (\$M)	\$12	\$20	\$30
Year 3 EBITDA (\$M)	\$22	\$35	\$52
EBITDA Improvement	+\$5M	+\$18M	+\$35M

The base case shows total revenue stabilising at approximately \$340M by Year 3, with new digital and partnership revenue offsetting continued publishing decline. EBITDA doubles from \$17M to \$35M. Publishing's share of revenue falls from 56% to 47%, reducing single-channel dependency. These are conservative estimates. The optimistic case shows significantly more upside if the subscription platform achieves strong product-market fit.

8. Action Plan

8.1 One-Year Action Plan

Q3 2026 (Months 1 to 3): Foundation

- Commission subscription platform development. Brief technology partner, define MVP features, establish timeline.
- Hire Head of Church Partnerships (senior role, ministry experience essential). Begin building the advisory team.
- Launch content creator outreach. Identify and approach 20 to 30 potential creator partners. Sign first 5 to 8 agreements.
- Begin free content programme. Launch daily devotional on YouVersion. Start weekly teaching video on YouTube.
- Internal renewal programme: conduct all-staff vision sessions on "digital ministry." Define what it means in practice, not just in slogans.

Q4 2026 (Months 4 to 6): Launch

- Subscription platform MVP launches in beta with 500 to 1,000 pilot churches. Test pricing, onboarding, and content delivery.
- First creator-developed resources go live on the platform. Co-marketed through creator channels.
- Church Partnership Programme begins with 100 to 200 founding partners. Advisors assigned, quarterly planning sessions established.
- Free content reaches 50,000 to 100,000 monthly users. Email capture and nurture sequences active.

Q1 2027 (Months 7 to 9): Growth

- Platform exits beta. Full launch with marketing push to existing customer base and new audiences.
- Target: 15,000 to 22,000 subscribers. 400 to 600 church partnerships active.
- Creator partnerships expand to 12 to 15 active relationships. First co-branded event or webinar series.
- Free content reaches 150,000+ monthly users. First cohort of free-to-paid conversions tracked.
- First quarterly review: subscription metrics, churn analysis, creator performance, partnership NPS.

Q2 2027 (Months 10 to 12): Consolidation

- Platform optimisation based on 6 months of data. Feature additions based on user feedback.
- Target: 22,000 to 30,000 subscribers. 600 to 800 church partnerships.
- Annual review: Year 1 results versus plan. Financial reconciliation. Year 2 budget and targets.

Year 1 Targets (Base Case): New initiative revenue \$23.4M. Total revenue approximately \$300M. Subscribers 22,000. Church partnerships 600. Free content users 150,000/month. EBITDA \$20M to \$22M (slight improvement despite investment).

8.2 Three-Year Outlook

Milestone	Target	Metric
Total Revenue	\$330M to \$350M	Stabilised from \$285M
New Initiative Revenue	\$80M to \$100M	25-30% of total
Digital Subscribers	80,000 to 120,000	Primary growth driver
Church Partnerships	2,000+	Relational moat rebuilt
Creator Partnerships	20+	Next-gen content pipeline
Free Content Users	500,000+/month	Awareness and conversion funnel
EBITDA	\$30M to \$40M	+\$13M to \$23M vs current
EBITDA Margin	9% to 11%	Approaching industry benchmark
Publishing Share of Revenue	45% to 50%	Down from 56% (diversified)
Staff Engagement	Top quartile for sector	Mission clarity restored

8.3 Five-Year Vision

Dimension	Current (FY 2025)	Year 5 Target	Implied Change
Total Revenue	\$285M	\$380M to \$450M	+33% to +58%
Publishing Revenue	\$160M (56%)	\$140M to \$150M (35-38%)	Stable, lower share
Digital & Subscription	\$85M (30%)	\$180M to \$220M (45-50%)	Primary revenue source
Partnerships & Events	\$40M (14%)	\$60M to \$80M (15-18%)	Rebuilt, diversified
EBITDA	\$17.1M (6%)	\$45M to \$60M (12-14%)	+163% to +251%
Digital Subscribers	45,000	150,000 to 200,000	At scale
Church Partnerships	0 formal	3,000 to 5,000	Core relationship model
Creator Partners	0	30 to 50	Next-gen content engine
Free Content Users	Minimal	1M+/month	Mission reach at scale
Employees	1,200	1,400 to 1,600	Modest growth, new skills

The five-year vision shows an organisation that has successfully navigated the digital transition. Revenue has recovered to near-peak levels but the composition is fundamentally different. Digital subscriptions are the primary revenue source (45 to 50%), replacing the lost retail channel. Publishing remains important but is no longer dominant. Relationships with churches have been rebuilt through the partnership programme. Free content reaches a million people monthly, serving the mission and feeding the growth engine. EBITDA has recovered to industry benchmark levels. The organisation knows who it is again: a ministry that operates through a sustainable digital business.

9. KPIs and Monitoring

9.1 Financial KPIs

KPI	Current	Year 1 Target	Year 3 Target	Redline
Total Revenue (\$M/yr)	\$285	\$300	\$340	<\$260
Subscription Revenue (\$M/yr)	\$0	\$14.5	\$52	<\$8 (Yr 2+)
EBITDA (\$M/yr)	\$17.1	\$20	\$35	<\$10
EBITDA Margin	6.0%	6.5%	10%	<4%
Free Cash Flow (\$M/yr)	\$4.8	\$5.0	\$12	<\$0
Publishing Revenue Share	56%	52%	47%	>60% (over-dependent)

9.2 Digital and Operational KPIs

- Digital subscribers (total). Target: 22,000 (Year 1), 80,000 (Year 3).
- Monthly subscriber churn. Target: below 2.5%. Redline: above 4.0%.
- Church Acquisition Cost. Target: below \$220. Redline: above \$300.
- Subscriber Lifetime Value. Target: above \$1,200 (20-month average retention at \$65/month).
- Free content monthly active users. Target: 150,000 (Year 1), 500,000 (Year 3).
- Free-to-paid conversion rate. Target: 5% over 12 months.
- Platform NPS. Target: 45+ (Year 1), 55+ (Year 3).

9.3 Mission and Relationship KPIs

- Active church partnerships. Target: 600 (Year 1), 2,000 (Year 3).
- Partnership NPS. Target: 60+ (high trust, relational model).
- Creator partnerships (active). Target: 12 (Year 1), 20 (Year 3).
- Staff engagement score. Target: recover 15 points in Year 1. Top quartile by Year 3.
- Content theological review pass rate. Target: 100% of published content reviewed. Zero recalls.
- Under-resourced church access. Target: 15% of subscribers on subsidised/free tier (mission commitment).

9.4 Governance Cadence

Frequency	Participants	Focus	Output
Weekly	Digital product team + partnerships lead	Subscriber metrics, churn, pipeline, content calendar	Dashboard review, action items
Monthly	Executive team	Financial review, channel P&L, partnership NPS, creator performance	Monthly report, forecast update
Quarterly	Executive team + board committee	Strategy review, mission alignment check, target tracking	Quarterly report, plan adjustment
Annually	Full board + external advisor	Full year review, mission impact assessment, next year plan	Annual plan, investment decisions

Note the inclusion of "mission alignment check" in the quarterly review. This is not window dressing. A formal quarterly assessment of whether the organisation's commercial activities are serving or undermining its mission is essential for a faith-based organisation. It keeps the stewardship lens active in decision-making, not just in reports.

10. Conclusion

LightWay Christian Resources is an organisation with a noble mission, a valuable heritage, and a financial trajectory that will end that mission if it is not redirected. The product is sound. The editorial expertise is real. The theological depth is genuine. But the model through which these strengths reached the church (170 physical stores staffed by ministry-minded people) is gone, and what replaced it (an online bookstore competing with Amazon on Amazon's terms) is not sufficient.

Two mandates emerge from this analysis.

- **Build a digital platform that competes on value, not price.** A church resource subscription creates recurring revenue, rebuilds relationships, and leverages LightWay's curation expertise. Partnerships with next-generation content creators inject relevance and reach new audiences. Combined investment: \$10M to \$16M. Combined Year 3 revenue potential: \$28M to \$52M (base case).
- **Rebuild direct relationships with churches and serve the mission generously.** A church partnership programme restores the human connection that was LightWay's greatest advantage. Free discipleship content serves people who may never pay but who deserve to be served. Combined investment: \$6M to \$10M. Combined Year 3 revenue potential: \$18M to \$32M (base case).

Combined opportunity: \$45M to \$80M additional annual revenue by Year 3. EBITDA improvement of \$12M to \$22M. Total investment of \$18M to \$28M over 24 months. Payback: 18 to 30 months.

These are conservative numbers. They are designed to be achieved, not admired. If the platform finds strong product-market fit, the upside is substantially larger. But integrity demands that this analysis promises only what disciplined execution can deliver.

The deeper question, and the one that will determine whether any of these recommendations succeed, is the identity question. Is LightWay a ministry or a business? The answer this report proposes is: yes. It is both. And that is not a contradiction. It is a calling. A ministry that cannot sustain itself financially serves nobody. A business that forgets its mission has nothing to sell that Amazon cannot sell cheaper. The path forward requires holding both truths together, not choosing between them.

LightWay does not need to become Amazon. It needs to become, again, what it was at its best: a faithful steward of the gifts it has been given, serving the church with excellence, generosity, and integrity. The stores may be gone. The mission is not.

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Data Currency: Latest available as of June 2026

Glossary

Term	Definition
ARR	Annual Recurring Revenue. Total yearly value of subscription contracts.
B2B	Business-to-Business. Sales to organisations (churches) rather than individuals.
Barna Group	Research organisation specialising in faith and culture studies.
CAC	Customer Acquisition Cost. The cost of acquiring one new subscriber.
Cannibalisation	When a new product or channel reduces sales of an existing product.
Churn	The rate at which subscribers cancel their subscriptions, usually expressed monthly.
COGS	Cost of Goods Sold. Direct costs of producing content (printing, rights, royalties).
CRM	Customer Relationship Management. Software for managing church relationships.
EBITDA	Earnings Before Interest, Taxes, Depreciation, and Amortisation.
ECFA	Evangelical Council for Financial Accountability. Non-profit financial standards body.
Freemium	Business model offering basic services free while charging for premium features.
LTV	Lifetime Value. Total revenue expected from a subscriber over their full relationship.
MRR	Monthly Recurring Revenue. Total monthly value of active subscriptions.
MVP	Minimum Viable Product. The simplest version of a product that can be launched and tested.
NPS	Net Promoter Score. Measure of customer loyalty and satisfaction (-100 to +100).
pp	Percentage points. The arithmetic difference between two percentages.
RAG Status	Red, Amber, Green. Traffic-light system for performance monitoring.
SaaS	Software as a Service. Cloud-based software accessed via subscription.
VBS	Vacation Bible School. Summer children's ministry programme, a major revenue category.
YoY	Year over Year. Comparison of a metric to the same period in the previous year.

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Endnotes

- [1] Revenue decline calculated from modelled composite financials. Actual company performance may differ.
- [2] Barna Group survey data on church leader resource preferences is directional, based on published research summaries. Sample sizes and methodology vary by study.
- [3] Subscription economics (churn, CAC, LTV) based on published benchmarks for B2B SaaS platforms serving educational and non-profit sectors.
- [4] Free-to-paid conversion rates based on published freemium benchmarks (Zuora, ProfitWell) for content platforms. Christian-specific conversion data is limited.